TRT 06

DHEA (prasterone)

Steroid hormone made mainly by the adrenal glands, which the body turns into androgens and estrogens



CLASS	STUDIED FOR	HUMAN EVIDENCE	US STATUS
Hormone (steroid)	Aging, body composition	Large trials; FDA approved (women)	FDA approved for women only (Intrarosa)

STUDIED FOR

- **Body composition** — HUMAN
- **Sexual function** — HUMAN
- **Bone** — HUMAN
- **Vaginal atrophy** — HUMAN

Supplement and drug differ. The approved product is a vaginal insert for women. Oral DHEA is sold as a dietary supplement, which FDA does not review before sale.

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Meta-analysis: 25 RCTs, 1,353 older men
- 2-year RCT: no change in strength or body comp
- Intrarosa approved 2016 (women)

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Long-term safety in men
- Half-life in men
- Effects on fertility
- Supplement contents

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

DHEA ▶ Conversion ▶ Androgens ▶ Estrogens

- **Label:** an inactive steroid converted into active androgens and/or estrogens
- **In 14 older men,** oral DHEA raised estradiol and estrone, not testosterone
- **In men,** the mechanism of any effect is not established

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE	ROUTES STUDIED
Not established in men	By mouth (trials in men); vaginal insert (Intrarosa)
PHARMACOKINETICS	**SOLD AS**
Converted to androgens and estrogens (label)	Dietary supplement; Rx vaginal insert for women
MONITORED IN TRIALS	**SPORT (WADA)**
PSA, lipids, liver tests (trials in men)	Prohibited, class S1

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved only as Intrarosa (women)
FDA	Sold as a supplement; not reviewed before sale
WADA	Prohibited at all times (S1.1)

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Intrarosa prescribing information, Aug 2026
2. J Clin Endocrinol Metab, DHEA in elderly men meta-analysis, Sep 2013
3. WADA, 2026 Prohibited List

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